their objectives in Berlin. Western attitudes marked ‘a paradigmatic shift’ in international politics. They also signalled willingness to risk destruction of their own cities, although, as Harold Macmillan privately explained to President Eisenhower in 1959:

> it would not be easy to persuade the British people that it was their duty to go to war in defence of West Berlin. After all, in my lifetime we have been dealt two nearly mortal blows by the Germans. People in this country will think it paradoxical, to use a mild term, to have to prepare for an even more horrible war in order to defend the liberties of people who have tried to destroy us twice in this century.[5]

In Western eyes, the security of West Berlin, nevertheless, depended on the commitment of Western military forces to deter Soviet aggression. In this, West Berlin was a microcosm of the Federal Republic, to which NATO was committed. For many West Germans, the willingness of the United States to attack the Soviet Union with nuclear weapons would deter the USSR from attacking the FRG. At the same time, Chancellor Konrad Adenauer’s government remained staunchly committed to the reunification of Germany and therefore refused to recognise the German Democratic Republic (GDR). For the Soviets, memories of the German invasion were understandably bitter. Over twenty-seven million Soviet people had died in a war that had brought devastation and suffering on a scale unsurpassed in the history of conflict. Fear of a resurgent Germany was reinforced by West German rearmament and admission to NATO in May 1955. It was further fuelled by the prospect that Germans might come to possess nuclear weapons.

Nikita Khrushchev variously described Berlin as a ‘bone in the throat,’ a ‘malignant tumour’ in need of surgery, and ‘the West’s balls’. ‘Every time I want to make the West scream, I squeeze on Berlin,’ he boasted.[6] On 27 November 1958 Khrushchev threatened that if no agreement was reached on a permanent treaty to end the Second World War within six months, he would formally recognise East Germany. Eisenhower and his NATO allies